

Spain



Area 194,896 sq miles
(504,782 sq km)

Population 46.5 million

Capital Madrid

Currency Euro

Official languages Spanish, Galician, Basque, and Catalan

Life expectancy 81 years

Occupying a major part of the Iberian Peninsula of southwestern Europe, Spain has an Atlantic as well as a Mediterranean coast. Spain was ruled by the military dictator General Franco from 1939 until his death in 1975. His successor, King Juan Carlos I, peacefully led the nation toward democracy, and the first free elections were

held in 1977. Although the economy saw rapid growth in the 1980s, a financial slump in 2008 led to severe unemployment. However, tourism has been a key strength of the Spanish economy; the country's vibrant culture, dance, music, and food attract many visitors.

► **CASA BATLLÓ, BARCELONA**
This remarkable landmark in Barcelona, Spain, was built by Antoni Gaudí, the celebrated Spanish architect. Among its unique features is its arched roof, which is shaped like a dragon's back, with ceramic tiles for scales.



Portugal



Area 35,672 sq miles
(92,391 sq km)

Population 10.7 million

Capital Lisbon

Currency Euro

Official language Portuguese

Life expectancy 78 years

Portugal lies on the western side of the Iberian Peninsula. Its long-standing dictatorship ended with a bloodless military coup (takeover) in 1974. Portugal has been a multiparty democracy since then. The economic slowdown in 2008 pushed the Portuguese economy into severe debt.

Malta



Area 122 sq miles
(316 sq km)

Population 400,000

Capital Valletta

Currency Euro

Official languages Maltese and English

Life expectancy 79 years

Malta is a group of tiny islands that lie between Europe and North Africa. Only the islands Kemmuna, Gozo, and Malta are inhabited. After being ruled by successive colonial powers, Malta gained its independence from the UK in 1964. Tourism is Malta's chief source of income.

Cyprus



Area 3,571 sq miles
(9,250 sq km)

Population 1.1 million

Capital Nicosia

Currency Euro

Official languages Greek and Turkish

Life expectancy 79 years

The island of Cyprus lies south of Turkey in the eastern Mediterranean. The island was partitioned in 1974, with the north inhabited by Turkish Cypriots and the south by Greek Cypriots. However, Northern Cyprus is officially recognized as an independent state only by Turkey.

Greece



Area 50,942 sq miles
(131,940 sq km)

Population 11.4 million

Capital Athens

Currency Euro

Official language Greek

Life expectancy 79 years

The Hellenic Republic, or Greece as it is popularly known, is surrounded by the Aegean, Ionian, and Mediterranean seas, and includes about 2,000 islands. Greece's idyllic beaches and historical sites are very popular with tourists. The country has had debt problems since 2009.



▲ **DRINKING CUP**
This Ancient Greek drinking cup with handles rising above the brim, called a kantharos, has been styled in the shape of a donkey's head.

Albania



Area 11,100 sq miles
(28,748 sq km)

Population 3.2 million

Capital Tirana

Currency Albanian lek

Official language Albanian

Life expectancy 76 years

A mountainous country lying at the southeastern end of the Adriatic Sea, Albania is one of the poorest countries in Europe. Albania is home to a small minority of ethnic Greeks. Dominated by the Communist ruler Enver Hoxha for 40 years, it became a democracy in 1991.